

News Weekly

So called "Snufflepagus" fish discovered

Marine biologists have identified a new species of ghost pipefish, named *Solenostomus snuffleupagus*, due to its shaggy, reddish-orange appearance reminiscent of Mr. Snuffleupagus from *Sesame Street*. This discovery was detailed in the *Journal of Fish Biology*, highlighting the fish's unique resemblance to Big Bird's woolly friend. The species was first spotted in 2003 off the coast of Papua New Guinea by marine biologist David Harasti, who spent nearly two decades in search of another specimen. In 2022, Harasti and ichthyologist Graham Short found a pair in the Great Barrier Reef, aided by local scuba divers' reports.

Ghost pipefishes are related to seahorses and are known for their ability to blend into their surroundings. *Solenostomus snuffleupagus*, no longer than a matchstick, mimics red macroalgae with its dense, hair-like filaments. While delicate in appearance, CT scans revealed these tiny creatures are predators. Citizen science platforms have confirmed sightings across the southwestern Pacific, including Tonga and New Caledonia.

(Source: Science News)



David hat-trick sees Canada thrash Qatar for first World Cup win

Canada celebrated its inaugural World Cup victory with a commanding 6-0 win over a depleted Qatar team in Vancouver, despite a serious injury sustained by Ismaïl Koné. Qatar's lackluster defense and red cards issued to Homam al Amin and Assim Madibo significantly contributed to Canada's triumph. Cyle Larin and Jonathan David scored early, with David netting twice before the half-time break. The second half saw Madibo receive a red card following a harsh challenge on Koné, who had to be stretchered off the field. Nathan Saliba scored in the 65th minute as a tribute to Koné, and David completed his hat trick shortly thereafter. Canada now requires just one more point to secure the top position in Group B, with their next match scheduled against Switzerland.

((Source: ESPN))



Possible prototype to Stonehenge discovered

A recent archaeological discovery in southwest England may illuminate the origins of Stonehenge. Experts suggest that a 5,000-year-old structure found in Bulford, Wiltshire, could have been a precursor to the iconic monument. This ancient site consists of two wooden poles set 120 meters apart, aligning with the sun's position during the summer and winter solstices, mirroring Stonehenge's alignment.

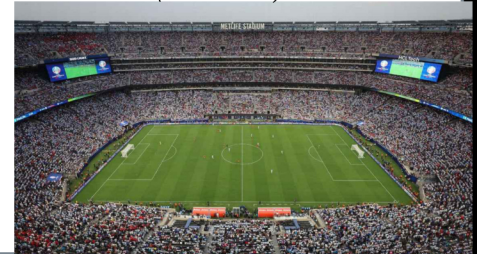
Archaeologist Phil Harding, leading the investigation, confirmed through radiocarbon dating that these poles were installed around the same time as Stonehenge's initial earthworks, predating the stones by 500 years. Harding emphasized the significance of the sun to prehistoric communities, who could track its movements with remarkable precision.

Fabio Silva, a skyline archaeologist, demonstrated that the alignment of the poles with the solstices was intentional. This finding suggests that Stonehenge was part of a broader, ongoing interaction between ancient people, their landscape, and the celestial bodies. (Source: CNN)



60 people get World Cup tickets for free due to website error

FIFA found itself in a pickle when it mistakenly handed out free World Cup tickets to about 60 lucky fans due to a website glitch. Oopsie-daisy! With a sheepish grin, FIFA asked these fans to kindly cough up the cash. This little hiccup is just one chapter in FIFA's ongoing ticket saga, now catching the eye of New York and New Jersey's top legal eagles due to possible consumer protection slip-ups. While claiming games were sold out, tickets were still magically available, prompting FIFA to set up a resale platform with a cheeky 15% commission to outfox ticket scalpers. And brace yourselves—the 2026 World Cup tickets come with a beefier price tag, which FIFA says will help boost its member federations. Game on! (Source: ESPN)



The oldest known plague outbreak struck hunter-gatherers 5,500 years ago

Approximately 5,500 years ago, the oldest-known traces of plague were found in hunter-gatherer burials in Siberia, reshaping our understanding of the disease's history. These traces, discovered at one of four ancient burial sites, predate previous evidence by several hundred years. This indicates that hunter-gatherers experienced plague outbreaks long before farming and settled communities emerged, as reported in *Nature* on June 17.

Archaeologist Ruairidh Macleod from the University of Oxford expressed surprise at this finding, as large outbreaks were generally believed to occur in densely populated settlements. Macleod's team found numerous children's graves near Lake Baikal and initially aimed to understand these through DNA analysis. They examined 46 individuals from four sites and found that 18 were infected with *Yersinia pestis*, the bacterium causing plague, and were buried hastily. Previously, the oldest traces of plague were from Latvia and a Neolithic farming site in Sweden, around 5,000 years ago, supporting the belief that plague became widespread with farming. However, evidence from Lake Baikal suggests otherwise, with *Y. pestis* likely being a natural reservoir for *Y. pestis*. The strain found in Siberia was deadly and virulent, indicating that plague diverged from a milder form at least 5,700 years ago, likely in Central Asia. Molecular biologist Nicolás Rascovan views the Lake Baikal discovery as strong evidence against the idea that agriculture drove plague emergence. He notes that much of *Y. pestis* evolution remains unexplored, suggesting more surprises may yet be uncovered in the history of the plague.

Jokes

What kind of motorcycle does a rabbit ride?

A Yamahoppy.

Connections



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Masala Lamb Racks

- Ingredients for the Lamb
 - 1 rack of lamb (about 2–2.5 lbs), frenched
 - 2–4 cloves garlic, crushed or minced
 - ½ tbsp garam masala
 - ½ tsp turmeric powder
 - ½–1 tsp cayenne or chili powder (adjust to taste)
 - 1 tsp ground coriander
 - 2 tbsp oil of choice
 - 1–2 tsp kosher salt
 - ½–1 tsp black pepper
 - Rosemary (Optional)
 - Optional: ¼ cup Greek yogurt for a marinade base to enhance tenderness
- To prepare the masala rub, start by mixing garam masala, turmeric, cayenne, coriander, garlic, and ginger in a small bowl. Add either olive oil or ghee, and if you're using yogurt, blend it into a smooth paste for coating the lamb. Ensure the spice paste is rubbed thoroughly over all sides of the lamb, including between the bones. For a richer flavor, cover and marinate the lamb for at least an hour, ideally overnight in the fridge.
- When ready to cook, preheat your oven to 450°F (230°C) and arrange the rack in the center. Optionally, sear the lamb in a hot skillet with oil or ghee for 3–4 minutes per side to achieve a golden crust before roasting. Position the lamb bone-side down on a roasting pan. Roast for 15–20 minutes for medium-rare or a bit longer for medium doneness. Check with a meat thermometer. After roasting, let the lamb rest under loosely tented foil for 10–15 minutes.

